international diplomatic intervention to end the conflict. As Gurmeet Kanwal explains, “We war-game this all the time and we do not trip their [strategic] red lines.” According to Arun Sahgal, Cold Start “will give Pakistan no option but to bring down its nuclear thresholds. But this shouldn’t really worry us. We don’t think Pakistan will cross the nuclear Rubicon.”[77]

However, given the uncertainties that would be inherent in a large-scale Indo-Pakistani conflict, such a benign outcome is hardly guaranteed. For example, an unexpectedly rapid and extensive Indian victory or failure to achieve a quick diplomatic resolution to the conflict could result in a far more extreme Pakistani response than the Indians currently anticipate. India’s planning for a carefully controlled limited war with Pakistan could prove to be overly optimistic. As a senior American defense official familiar with Cold Start worries, the Indians “think that they can fight three or four days and the international community will stop it. And they believe that they can fight through a nuclear exchange. But there are unintended consequences. Calibrate a conventional war and nuclear exchange with Pakistan? It doesn’t work that way.”[78]

It is worth noting that a major Indo-Pakistani crisis could erupt even without a deliberate decision by the Pakistani government to provoke India. The Islamist forces that the Pakistanis have nurtured in recent decades have taken on a life of their own and do not always act at Islamabad’s behest. Indeed, they often behave in ways inimical to Pakistani interests, such as launching attacks on Pakistani security forces, government officials, and political figures.[79] And even an improved political and security environment in Kashmir may be insufficient to satisfy the militants; jihad organizations may see eventual control of territory within India proper, rather than the mere liberation of Kashmir, as the true prize in their struggle. Nasr Javed, a Lashkar-e-Toiba official, delivering a speech after the evening prayer at the Quba Mosque in Islamabad on February 5, 2008, stated: “India is also afraid of *jihad*. India fears that if the *Mujahideen* liberated Kashmir through *jihad*, then, it will be very difficult to keep [the] rest of India under control. *Jihad* will spread from Kashmir to other parts of India. The Muslims will be ruling India again.” He went on to say, “We want to tell the Kashmiri brothers that